

CHAPTER 8

Silent evidence bears the name *wrong reference class* in the nasty field of philosophy of probability, *anthropic bias* in physics, and *survivorship bias* in statistics (economists present the interesting attribute of having rediscovered it a few times while being severely fooled by it).

Confirmation: Bacon says in *On Truth*, “No pleasure is comparable to the standing upon the vantage ground of truth (a hill not to be commanded and where the air is always clear and serene), and to see the errors, and wanderings, and mists, and tempests, in the vale below.” This easily shows how great intentions can lead to the confirmation fallacy.

Bacon did not understand the empiricists: He was looking for the golden mean. Again, from *On Truth*:

There are three sources of error and three species of false philosophy; the sophistic, the empiric and the superstitious. ... Aristotle affords the most eminent instance of the first; for he corrupted natural philosophy by logic—thus he formed the world of categories. ... Nor is much stress to be laid on his frequent recourse to experiment in his books on animals, his problems and other treatises, for he had already decided, without having properly consulted experience as the basis of his decisions and axioms. ... The empiric school produces dogmas of a more deformed and monstrous nature than the sophistic or theoretic school; not being founded in the light of common notions (which however poor and superstitious, is yet in a manner universal and of general tendency), but in the confined obscurity of a few experiments.

Bacon’s misconception may be the reason it took us a while to understand that they treated history (and experiments) as mere and vague “guidance,” i.e., epilogues.

Publishing: Allen (2005), Klebanoff (2002), Epstein (2001), de Bellaigue (2004), and Blake (1999). For a funny list of rejections, see Bernard (2002) and White (1982). Michael Korda’s memoir, Korda (2000), adds some color to the business. These books are anecdotal, but we will see later that books follow steep scale-invariant structures with the implication of a severe role for randomness.

Anthropic bias: See the wonderful and comprehensive discussion in Bostrom (2002). In physics, see Barrow and Tipler (1986) and Rees (2004). Sornette (2004) has Gott’s derivation of survival as a power law. In finance, Sullivan et al. (1999) discuss survivorship bias. See also Taleb (2004a). Studies that ignore the bias and state inappropriate conclusions: Stanley and Danko (1996) and the more foolish Stanley (2000).

Manuscripts and the Phoenicians: For survival and science, see Cisne (2005). Note that the article takes into account physical survival (like fossil), not cultural, which implies a selection bias. Courtesy Peter Bevelin.